

were looking forward to playing Shi Yuqi in China. How did you develop this big-match temperament?

Last year, I won against a few top players (Ayush beat Chou Tien Chen in the semifinals of the USA Open — my first World Tour 300 title — and later beat Kodai Naraoka at the Australian Open). That played a role. It gave me the confidence that I can compete with the best in the world.

I think it's fun to play against top players. I enjoy that, and I'm trying to give my best.

What do you think went wrong in the final against Shi Yuqi?

I think in the final, Shi didn't give me a chance to attack. He didn't let me dominate at the net, and I couldn't create any attacking opportunities. The semifinals had gone a similar way. I had lost the first game (against both Kunlavut Vitidsarn and Shi), and in the second, I took a lead (I was 7-2 up) against Shi.

Against Kunlavut, I think I was able to stay more patient in the longer rallies. Against Shi, I was prepared to be patient, but in the end, I gave him a chance to get back into the game, and he regained his confidence. Once he found his rhythm, he started playing some really sharp shots.

How hard has the loss been for you?

The loss in the final was really tough. I really wanted to win that match. But I think it's a great learning experience.

The way Shi played, he didn't allow me to come back into the match. It was a good lesson. There are things I've learned that I need to do.

If there's one area I want to improve, it's the physical side. I need to get physically stronger. If I want to be among the best, it's an area I need to work on.

You've recently started training with Indonesian coach Irwansyah (who was earlier exclusively coaching P.V. Sindhu). What was that like?

It's been only two weeks since I started training with him. With Irwansyah, the sessions are longer. I hadn't been doing as much physical work since I knew I didn't have much time before the Asian Championships, but even the sessions we were doing were quite a bit longer and tougher than the ones I had been doing previously.

You seemed to have gone off social media until the final of the Asian Championships. Did you see

Sindhu's post on X describing you as a 'generational talent'?

I had actually decided I wasn't going to post anything about the tournament until the final got over. But I was still looking at social media. I was very happy to see the good things in Sindhu's post. I've been training with her for some time (at the Centre for Badminton Excellence in Bengaluru). We've actually done sparring and practised together.

There are a few things in common with Sindhu. You are pretty tall as well. How does that help you?

There are both advantages and disadvantages. On the plus side, I can achieve really sharp angles and hit shots from steep angles. But on the other side, it's not easy to defend and get low on the court. I have to really work on building my leg strength.

You trained with Viktor Axelsen a couple of years ago and he said that you remind him of himself when he was younger. What do you make of that?

It makes you feel great when your idol says good things about you.

There's a lot I can learn from him.

Viktor is really strong, and he gets really low to the ground, which gives him great defence. It's really surprising he can do that with his height. This is something I picked up on and want to do if I want to be among the very best.

After reaching the Asian Championships final, there will be a lot of expectations from you.

I see the expectations as a challenge. I'm enjoying it and looking forward to the year. There are two major competitions we are targeting this year — the World Championships and the Asian Games.



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT